

Erich Mendelsohn

The icon for expressionist architecture is the curvaceous and organic Einstein Tower in Potsdam (opposite), built by German Erich Mendelsohn (1887–1953) in 1921. Aiming for a synthesis of functionalism with expressionism, Mendelsohn blends rationality with dynamism. Specially designed to test the theories of Albert Einstein, the building was constructed from brick, concrete and block render, and includes an underground laboratory with a vertical telescope and domed observatory roof. Outcroppings at each side provide stability for the squat tower, while round windows are recessed in niches.

Although he drew on elements of modernism, Mendelsohn's architecture was individual, with curves, rhythmical forms and an imaginative use of glass, often emphasizing horizontals. Fleeing Nazi Germany in 1933, he went to Brussels and then London. With Serge Chermayeff (1900–96), he designed the De La Warr Pavilion in East Sussex (1933–5), one of Britain's first modernist buildings and a spectacular example of his style.

